

2.2.2 Division by district

The 5 provinces established in 1833 by the Colebrooke Reform consisted of 23 districts. The boundaries of these districts have been subject to changes from time to time and due to these changes, the number of districts has changed in subsequent censuses. This is shown in the table 2.1 below.

Although the division of administrative districts changed from 1871 to 1981, in 2001 the country's territory was divided into 25 administrative districts, which remains the same today.

Table 2.1 : Evolution of the Number of Administrative Districts In Sri Lanka from 1871 to 2024

District	Census Year														
	1871	1881	1891	1901	1911	1921	1931	1946	1953	1963	1971	1981	2001	2012	2024
Total	18	21	22	20	20	20	20	20	20	22	22	24	25	25	25
Colombo	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Negambo		x	x												
Gampaha												x	x	x	x
Kalutara		x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Kandy	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Matale	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Nuwara Eliya	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Badulla	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Galle	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Matara	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Hambantota	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Jaffna	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Mannar	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Vavuniya		x	x					x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Mullaitivu	x	x	x	x	x	x	x					x	x	x	x
Kilinochchi													x	x	x
Batticaloa	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Ampara										x	x	x	x	x	x
Trincomalee	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Kurunegala	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Puttalam	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Chilaw			x	x	x	x	x	x	x						
Anuradhapura	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Polonnaruwa										x	x	x	x	x	x
Moneragala										x	x	x	x	x	x
Ratnapura	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x
Kegalle	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x	x